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"IT WAS A perfect day," posted famous Italian chef Massimo Bottura to his 1.5 million Instagram followers recently, along with a selfie with an elderly Japanese man. Bottura is typically on the receiving end of selfies, but this time it was special.

The man standing alongside Bottura was the 97-year-old legendary Japanese chef Jiro Ono. In 2007, his eponymous restaurant, hidden under an unassuming subway stop in Tokyo's Ginza district, became the world's first sushi restaurant to be awarded three Michelin stars.

In 2011, American film director David Gelb made Ono the hero of a documentary titled *Jiro Dreams of Sushi*, using his inspirational life story to showcase the determination and decades of training that Japanese chefs endure to become sushi masters. And in 2014, Ono served 20 pieces of the freshest *nigiri* sushi to then US President Barack Obama who was promised 'the best sushi of his life' by his host, the then Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe (Obama later said it lived up to its billing).

Ono was born in Japan's Shizuoka prefecture and legend has it that he started working at a sushi restaurant at the age of seven. He moved to Tokyo to study as a sushi apprentice, working his way up to become a qualified sushi chef. By 1965, Ono had reached the sushi-master classification and opened his first restaurant, the Sukiyabashi Jiro. With just 10 counter seats and an *omakase*

(dishes decided by the chef) menu that changed daily depending on the fresh catch in the morning.

It is nearly impossible to get a reservation at Sukiyabashi Jiro unless you are the US President or a celebrity (David Beckham and Hugh Jackman are regulars). Reservations open months ahead and sell out in seconds. The impossibility of securing a reservation was the official reason cited by the Michelin guide in 2019 when they withdrew their stars.

But that only led to greater demand for the 10 coveted seats and

In March this year, after months of trying, I finally got in. An oddly-worded confirmation email hit my inbox before I left for Tokyo, along with a list of peculiar rules. Two of them stood out: (i) no photography is allowed in the restaurant; and (ii) please use perfume and other cosmetics sparingly.

How did I get in? A tiny proportion of seats are reserved for those who are vouched for by a small clique of well-connected concierges at Tokyo's top hotels, and I was lucky enough to be at the hotel with



PHOTO DAVID BECKHAM/FACEBOOK



THE FIRST SUSHI RESTAURANT TO BE AWARDED THREE MICHELIN STARS, IT IS ALMOST IMPOSSIBLE TO GET A RESERVATION AT SUKIYABASHI JIRO

Sukiyabashi Jiro came to be known as the 'world's most difficult restaurant reservation'. Wealthy global food enthusiasts wait years for bookings, while others resort to the grey market, buying seats at significant premiums (the official price: 50,000 yen, or around ₹30,000, per person).

the best-networked concierge.

The day arrived. I reached the restaurant at 11 am, an hour early. 'Sorry, we are closed' read a signboard, but a peephole allowed a view of the team scrubbing the counters inside. At 11:59 am a youthful man dressed in white appeared at the door and